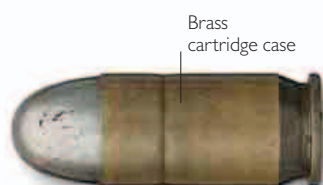


SHOWCASE

COLT MODEL 1911

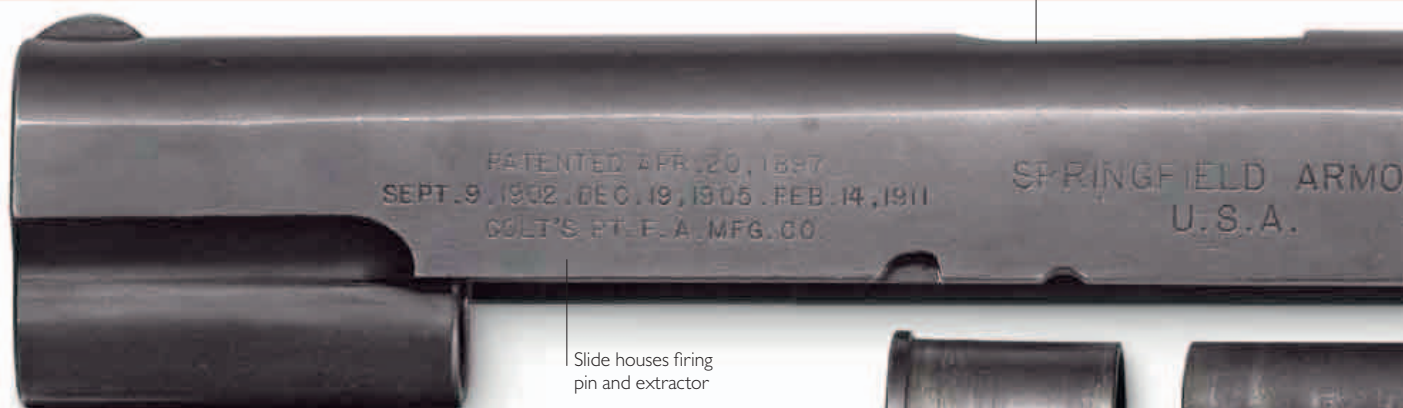
This all-time classic recoil-operated pistol (see p.305) has its origins in the work of John Browning in the 1890s. It used the .45in ACP (Automatic Colt Pistol) cartridge, which delivered a bullet with twice the energy of the 9mm cartridges favored in Europe. Adopted by the US government in 1911, it is still in limited service, a record for a military handgun.



Brass cartridge case

▲ .45IN ACP CARTRIDGE

Designed by Browning in 1904, this powerful center-fire cartridge is also used by the Thompson submachine-gun (see p.212–13).



Slide houses firing pin and extractor

▲ SLIDE AND RECOIL SPRING HOUSING

The slide houses the barrel, recoil spring, and breechblock. When the bullet is fired, the slide recoils backward, extracting the empty case and cocking the hammer. Driven forward by the recoil spring, the slide then feeds a new cartridge into the chamber. The hammer remains cocked until the trigger is pulled, at which point it strikes the firing pin.

► RECOIL SPRING

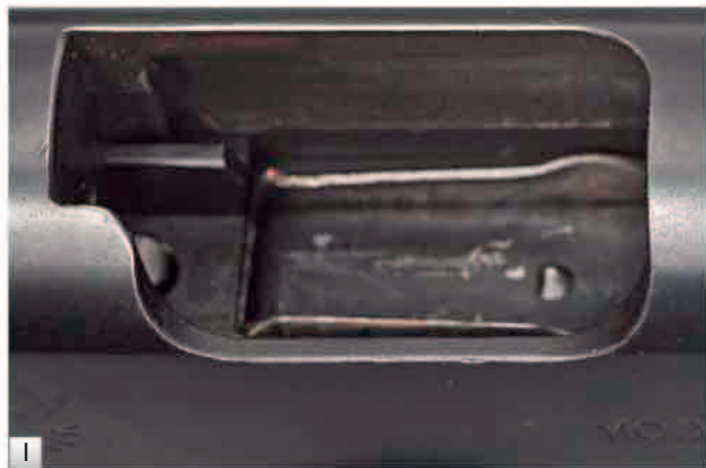
After the gun is fired and the slide has moved backward, the recoil spring forces it forward again, feeding a new cartridge into the chamber and sealing the breech ready for firing.



Recoil spring

► REAR SIGHT

This steel block with a “V” notch is fixed into a dovetail slot on the slide. The rear sight is set in correct position at the factory and is not adjustable.



1

▲ EJECTION PORT

The ejection port is an aperture cut in the upper portion near the rear end of the slide to allow the ejection of empty cases when the gun is fired.

Ejection port



2

▲ RECEIVER, OR MAIN FRAME

The receiver houses the magazine and the main elements of the firing mechanism. These are the trigger, sear (not seen), hammer, mainspring (not seen, located in the butt), grip safety, safety catch, and a disconnect (not seen) to prevent full automatic fire. The receiver also houses the slide stop, which holds the barrel on the receiver independently of the slide. If removed, it allows the slide to move forward off the receiver.